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Value-chain learning: Lessons from the textile industry

South Africa's textile industry reminds us that competitiveness is not born of cheap labour but of institutional density: logistics, design, supplier networks, and standards that allow firms to climb rather than cling to the value chain. It requires balanced rules of origin under the African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA), rules that reward collaboration over protectionism.

When those rules work, small countries like Lesotho can import yarn, South Africa can handle branding, Mauritius can export, and the continent as a whole can learn. The same principle applies in emerging clusters spanning from Kenya's agro-processing corridors to Morocco's green automotive sector, where coordination and learning matter more than scale alone. The lesson is simple: industrialisation is not a race to the bottom but a collective climb that the continent can achieve through the free continental agreement.

The AfCFTA as industrial commons

AfCFTA is not just a trade agreement; it is a platform for cooperation. Africa trades little with itself, not because of tariffs but because production systems are disconnected. Infrastructure, finance, and standards—not customs—are the real barriers. The new Digital Trade Protocol could become the spine of integration: digital platforms lower transaction costs, harmonise certification, and connect value chains across borders. Africa's industrial revolution will be as digital as it is industrial. Institutional choreography, a continental alignment council to synchronise incentives and track regional projects, is critical. Coordination, not competition, is the continent's new comparative advantage.

Thinking with China, not like China

China's rise offers Africa a crucial insight; however, success does not come from copying blueprints but from designing feedback loops. The continent requires its own context-sensitive dialogue with global partners, anchored unshakably in African agency. As Deborah Bräutigam, Director of the China–Africa Research Initiative, observed, China's industrial cooperation demonstrates that experimentation, rather than perfection, has been the foundation of its strength. The Chinese often refer to this steady development as 'crossing the river by feeling the stones': pragmatic trial, institutional learning, and rapid adjustment.

Africa can translate this ethos through its own context. For example, by turning Special Economic Zones into Industrial Learning Zones, where governments, firms, and universities co-design policy in motion. This is how partnership becomes co-development: each side contributing knowledge, not dependency.